Research on Listening Spaces

An artistic research project by Roman Ne

Working proposal for conversations with organisations and practitioners
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Research context

This research is being developed as an individual project within the CAS Arts and International Cooperation programme at Zurich University of the Arts (ZHdK).

The CAS programme examines the potential and limitations of artistic work in fragile contexts and in processes of social transformation and peacebuilding. It emphasises fair and sensitive international and intercultural collaboration. The programme addresses conflict sensitivity, reciprocity, power structures and the ethical questions that arise when artists, institutions and communities work across cultural and political contexts.

Within this framework, the project investigates how a listening space might be developed responsibly in relation to places shaped by displacement, instability or prolonged stress.

The work is an artistic and ethical inquiry. It does not present itself as therapy or assume that sound, silence or guided attention are inherently calming.

The research

The research investigates listening environments that people can enter, inhabit and leave freely. Through sound and a minimal sequence of spoken words, listeners' attention is guided between the body, the surrounding space and listening itself.

It asks whether such a space could offer a temporary sense of ease when stress, uncertainty or absence are experienced through bodily tension, repetitive thought or narrowed attention. This is an aim of the research rather than a promised outcome, and each person may experience the space differently.

Participants may sit or lie down, keep their eyes open or close them, fall asleep, and inhabit the space individually or collectively. They may enter and leave at any point. The research asks how the space can be carefully composed while allowing each person to choose the duration and nature of their engagement.

Research questions

Under what conditions could a temporary listening space be relevant, accessible and wanted within a context affected by displacement, instability or prolonged stress?

The research also asks:

- How do composed sound, existing environmental sound, spoken guidance, pauses and spatial arrangement affect the way the space is experienced?
- How can attention be gently directed between the body, sound and the immediate surroundings?
- How might a sense of silence be composed through sound, contrast, pauses and attention when the surrounding environment cannot be made quiet?
- What might allow participants to trust the situation enough to rest, listen or remain in the space?
- When might inward attention, low frequencies, pauses or spoken guidance be uncomfortable or inappropriate?
- How should the work be introduced and situated so that participation remains voluntary?
- How can the work be adapted through language, voice, space and local collaboration without losing its artistic character?

Background

The research grows out of an artistic practice developed through installations and listening sessions in different social and spatial contexts, particularly in Switzerland and Thailand.

An important point of departure for the present research was a series of sessions held in Yerevan and attended by people displaced from Nagorno-Karabakh alongside other participants. These sessions offered an initial experience of presenting the work in a context shaped by displacement, but they were not specifically adapted interventions.

The current research asks what would need to be understood, changed or developed before the work could responsibly enter another cultural context or a setting involving people experiencing displacement or prolonged instability.

Research process

The project combines artistic development, public prototyping, consultation and contextual research.

Current activities include:

- Developing and testing the artistic and technical prototype through sound, voice, pauses, duration, spatial arrangement, and conditions for entering and leaving.
- Testing the work with the general public and invited participants before considering work in contexts affected by displacement or prolonged instability.
- Working with the invited consultants and practitioners to examine the sequence, sound, guided attention, displacement context, safeguarding, and the boundaries between artistic, contemplative and therapeutic practice.
- Drawing on conversations with Armenian collaborators to consider how experiences of displacement should inform the prototype, its framing and its future use. A complete Armenian-language adaptation is not planned during this stage.
- Speaking with organisations and trusted intermediaries connected to Myanmar communities in Northern Thailand to understand whether the work could be relevant, wanted and responsibly situated.
- Developing initial guidelines for future localisation and adaptation, including translation, voice, local authorship, cultural assumptions, testing and safeguarding.

Consultation with Armenian collaborators during the CAS will draw on the experience of the Yerevan sessions and help examine how the prototype, its framing and its conditions of participation relate to displacement. This may later provide a basis for an Armenian-language version developed with contacts established in Yerevan, if such a version is considered relevant and wanted.

The research in Northern Thailand is exploratory. Its purpose is to understand whether the project could be relevant or wanted and what artistic, cultural, organisational and safeguarding conditions a possible future realisation would require.

Any future work involving people affected by displacement or living in otherwise fragile circumstances would be developed through an appropriate organisation or trusted intermediary. A realisation in such a context is not an intended outcome of the CAS itself.

Consultants

The research is being developed in dialogue with three consultants whose experience addresses different aspects of the project.

Sandeep Kumar Verma advises on yoga nidra, meditation, and guided relaxation practices. His contribution focuses on sequence structure, guided attention, secular adaptation, cultural assumptions, and the boundaries between artistic, contemplative, and therapeutic practices.

Gurgen Baghdasaryan advises on displacement in the Armenian context. Drawing on his knowledge of displaced communities and the displacement process, he contributes contextual guidance on lived realities, community relationships, appropriate language, and the conditions required for responsible engagement.

Mintralux “Miko” Danklang advises on sound-based practices and community engagement in displacement contexts. With a background in psychology and experience facilitating sound healing sessions with vulnerable communities along the Thailand–Myanmar border, she contributes practical knowledge of cultural sensitivity, trust-building, and the conditions for introducing sound-based activities in these environments.

Together, these perspectives connect the artistic development of the work with the practical and ethical questions that arise when working across cultural contexts and in relation to experiences of displacement.

Working principles

- The work may aim to support rest, ease or orientation, but it does not promise these outcomes.
- The work does not promise healing or present itself as therapy.
- Participation must be voluntary, people must be free to enter and leave.
- Sound, silence and inward attention are not assumed to be universally calming or beneficial. Closing the eyes, lying down, sleeping or completing the composition must never be required.
- Cultural and religious associations of sound and guided attention must be considered in each context.
- Trust and familiarity may require repeated encounters rather than a single intervention.
- Contextual knowledge should come from organisations, practitioners and communities themselves.
- The work should first be tested and revised in public and lower-risk settings.
- Work involving vulnerable communities should only proceed through an appropriate partnership, with clear safeguarding and consent processes.

Initial public experiment

An initial listening-space experiment is planned in Chiang Mai or Doi Saket, involving local participants in a public or community setting.

The experiment will explore the spatial arrangement, sound, spoken guidance, and conditions for voluntary participation. Particular attention will be given to how people approach, enter, spend time in, and leave the space.

Feedback from participants will help identify what feels accessible, unfamiliar, uncomfortable, or meaningful. Cultural and linguistic adaptations, including possible Thai-language guidance, will be explored as part of the process.

The findings will inform further development of the work before considering its application in contexts shaped by displacement or prolonged instability.

What I am seeking now

At this stage, I am seeking critical conversations rather than immediate access to a community.

I would value:

- Feedback on potential risks, cultural assumptions, consent, and safeguarding.
- Insight into local contexts, community relationships, and the conditions required to establish trust.
- Conversations with practitioners, organisations, and community representatives about whether and where the work could be relevant.
- Potential longer-term collaborations if the work proves relevant and welcomed.

Questions for organisations and practitioners

1. Relevance

Could a listening environment like this be meaningful within the contexts in which you work? Where, if anywhere, could it realistically belong?

2. Experience

What might make people want to enter and remain in such a space? What might make the experience uncomfortable, inaccessible or inappropriate?

3. Risks

What concerns would you have about sound, silence, guided attention, resting or sleeping within a shared space?

4. Conditions for engagement

What would need to change or be better understood before approaching an organisation or community seriously?

Research timeline

October–November 2026

Consultations with practitioners and organisations, contextual research, field visits, and initial artistic experiments.

December 2026

Development and public testing of a listening environment in Chiang Mai or Doi Saket, followed by evaluation and refinement.

January 2027

Documentation of research findings, artistic development, and a proposal for future realisations.

Beyond January 2027

Potential further development and collaborations in the Thailand–Myanmar border, depending on local interest and partnerships.

Contact

For conversation, feedback or potential collaboration:

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Thank you.